

Document 2: Influenza (Flu)

Metadata

- **ConditionID:** MED-002
- **Category:** Respiratory, Viral Infection
- **Keywords:** flu, influenza, high fever, severe aches, respiratory

Definition of Influenza

Influenza, commonly called the flu, is a highly contagious respiratory illness caused by influenza viruses (Type A and Type B) that infect the nose, throat, and sometimes the lungs. It can cause mild to severe illness.

Symptoms of Influenza

Unlike the common cold, flu symptoms usually come on suddenly and intensely. Symptoms include:

- High fever or feeling feverish/chills (though not everyone with the flu will have a fever)
- Severe muscle or body aches
- Pronounced fatigue and weakness
- Dry, persistent cough
- Headaches
- Sore throat and runny or stuffy nose

Treatment and Management for Influenza

Most people with the flu recover at home without medical intervention. Management includes:

- **Supportive Care:** Strict rest and high fluid intake to prevent dehydration.
- **Antiviral Drugs:** Prescription medications (e.g., Oseltamivir/Tamiflu) can lessen symptoms and shorten the illness by 1 to 2 days if started within 48 hours of symptom onset.
- **Symptom Relief:** OTC pain relievers (acetaminophen, ibuprofen) to reduce fever and aches.

When to Seek Medical Attention for Influenza

Emergency medical care is required for influenza if a patient exhibits:

- Difficulty breathing or shortness of breath.
- Persistent pain or pressure in the chest or abdomen.
- Persistent dizziness, confusion, or inability to arouse.
- Seizures or severe muscle weakness.